

HacXLerate 2026

CODE. CREATE. INNOVATE.

PARTICIPANT RULE BOOK – ROUND 1

Round 1: 24-Hour Campus Hackathon

Round 1 Window: October 5–11, 2026

Platform: byteXL Hackathon Platform

1. ABOUT HACXLERATE 2026

HacXLerate is byteXL's flagship national hackathon designed to bring students closer to real-world industry challenges.

Participants will work on problem statements presented by industry partners and use technology, creativity and problem-solving skills to build working solutions within a defined time limit.

HacXLerate 2026 follows a multi-stage journey:

Round 1 → Top 50 → Round 2 → Top 7 → Grand Finale

Round 1 will be conducted physically across participating partner colleges during the October 5–11, 2026 window.

2. ROUND 1 – AT A GLANCE

Particular	Details
Format	24-hour physical campus hackathon
Round 1 Window	October 5–11, 2026
Venue	Participating partner college campus
Team Size	3–5 members
Team Composition	Same college for the campus track
Problem Statements	Industry-backed real-world challenges
Problem Selection	First 2 hours

Problem Lock	Mandatory
Development Time	Remaining 22 hours
AI Usage	Allowed
Submission	Deployed solution + GitHub repository + project information + challenge-specific requirements
Evaluation	Automated evaluation followed by human evaluation
College Recognition	Top 3 teams
National Qualification	Top 50 teams overall

3. ELIGIBILITY

HacXLerate 2026 Round 1 is open to eligible undergraduate engineering students.

Participants must:

- Be currently enrolled undergraduate engineering students.
- Have a valid college ID.
- Participate through their registered team.
- Follow all HacXLerate rules and instructions.
- Be physically present at the designated college venue for the campus Round 1.

Students from different colleges cannot form a team for the on-campus Round 1.

Students outside the byteXL partner-college network may participate through the designated External Track, which has separate participation instructions.

4. TEAM RULES

4.1 Team Size

Each team must consist of **3–5 members**.

4.2 Team Composition

For the physical campus Round 1:

- All team members must belong to the same college.
- Only registered team members may participate.
- A student can participate in only one team.
- Team members must use their registered identities/details.

4.3 Team Changes

Once registration is completed, the team structure cannot be changed unless explicitly permitted by the HacXLerate organizing team.

Adding, removing or replacing members without authorization may lead to disqualification.

4.4 Team Lead

Every team must have a designated Team Lead.

The Team Lead is responsible for:

- Coordinating the team.
 - Accessing team-level actions on the platform.
 - Selecting and locking the problem statement.
 - Coordinating communication with the organizers when required.
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5. HACKATHON PLATFORM ACCESS

Participants will receive access to the **byteXL Hackathon Platform approximately 2–3 hours before the scheduled start of their Round 1 hackathon.**

Access details will be sent to the registered email address associated with the participant/team.

Participants are responsible for:

- Checking their registered email before the event.
- Checking Spam/Junk/Promotions folders if required.
- Logging in and verifying access before the hackathon begins.
- Informing the organizers immediately if they face an access issue.

Important

Receiving platform access before the event does **not** mean that the challenge can be started before the official hackathon start time.

The relevant HacXlerate Round 1 challenge will become accessible as per the official start time communicated for the participating college.

6. PHYSICAL PARTICIPATION

Round 1 is a **physical, on-campus hackathon** for partner-college participants.

Participants are expected to:

- Report to the designated college venue before the scheduled start.
- Remain available at the venue during the hackathon as instructed by the college/organizing team.
- Carry their own laptops and required accessories.
- Ensure their devices are sufficiently charged.
- Carry chargers and other required development equipment.
- Follow the instructions of the college and byteXL organizing teams.

Participants are responsible for their own devices and personal belongings.

7. PRE-HACKATHON BRIEFING

Participants must assemble at the designated venue **at least 30 minutes before the official hackathon start time.**

A pre-hackathon briefing will cover:

- Hackathon format
- Platform access
- Problem statement selection
- Problem lock mechanism
- Submission process
- Evaluation process
- AI usage
- Code of conduct
- Support and escalation process
- Important deadlines

If the college conducts a formal inauguration before the hackathon, participants must follow the schedule communicated by the college and organizers.

8. 24-HOUR HACKATHON FORMAT

The 24-hour Round 1 is divided into two key phases.

Phase 1 – Problem Selection & Lock

First 2 hours

Teams will:

1. Review the available problem statements.
2. Understand the challenge requirements.
3. Review the required functionalities and acceptance criteria.
4. Discuss internally.
5. Select one problem statement.
6. Lock the selected problem statement.

Phase 2 – Build & Submit

Remaining 22 hours

Teams will:

- Design the solution.
- Develop the required functionalities.

- Test the solution.
 - Deploy the solution.
 - Prepare the GitHub repository.
 - Complete all required project information.
 - Submit the final solution.
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9. PROBLEM STATEMENT SELECTION

Each team must select **ONE problem statement** from the challenges made available to them.

Who Can Select?

Only the Team Lead is authorized to select and lock the problem statement.

Team members may discuss and decide which challenge to work on, but the final selection and lock action must be completed by the Team Lead on the platform.

Selection Deadline

The problem statement must be selected and locked within the **first 2 hours of the hackathon**.

Failure to select a problem statement within the stipulated period may result in disqualification.

10. PROBLEM STATEMENT LOCK

This is one of the most important rules of HacXLerate 2026.

Once a problem statement is selected and locked:

It cannot be changed.

The selected problem statement will remain the team's problem statement throughout the entire HacXLerate journey:

Round 1 → Round 2 → Grand Finale

Therefore, teams are strongly advised to carefully understand the problem statement, required functionalities and evaluation expectations before locking their choice.

A team cannot request a change of problem statement after it has been locked.

11. PROBLEM STATEMENT REQUIREMENTS

Each challenge will provide the information required for teams to understand and build the solution.

This may include:

- Problem context
- Business/user problem
- Required functionalities
- Minimum feature requirements

- Acceptance criteria
- Technical expectations, where applicable
- Submission requirements
- Evaluation parameters
- Challenge-specific instructions

The exact evaluation weightage may differ between problem statements.

Teams are responsible for reading and understanding the complete challenge before beginning development.

12. USE OF AI

AI tools are allowed.

Participants may use AI tools during the hackathon for:

- Coding
- Debugging
- Research
- Ideation
- Architecture
- Design
- Testing
- Documentation
- Development assistance
- Other legitimate aspects of solution development

There is no restriction on the use of AI tools.

However, AI usage does not reduce the team's responsibility for its solution.

Teams are expected to:

- Understand what they build.
- Be able to explain their solution.
- Demonstrate ownership of their implementation.
- Apply their own creativity and problem-solving ability.
- Ensure that the submitted solution meets the challenge requirements.

AI assistance is allowed. Blind dependence is not a substitute for understanding, innovation or technical execution.

13. SOLUTION DEVELOPMENT

Teams may use technologies, frameworks, programming languages, libraries and development tools of their choice unless a specific challenge states otherwise.

Teams should focus on:

- Solving the actual problem.
- Building the required functionalities.
- Creating a usable solution.
- Ensuring the solution works as intended.
- Deploying the solution wherever required.
- Demonstrating innovation and technical depth.

Participants should prioritize a working and complete solution over unnecessary complexity.

14. SUBMISSION REQUIREMENTS

At the end of the 24-hour hackathon, each team must submit the required information through the byteXL Hackathon Platform.

The submission will generally include:

1. Project Information

- Project title
- Project summary
- Solution description
- Other information requested on the platform

2. GitHub Repository

Teams must provide the required GitHub repository information.

The repository should:

- Contain the project code.
- Be accessible to the evaluation team.
- Clearly represent the submitted solution.
- Include appropriate documentation/README wherever required.
- Clearly identify the technology stack and relevant implementation details.

3. Deployment & Nimbus

Teams are required to submit a **working deployment link** for their solution wherever specified as part of the challenge submission.

Participants are free to use the development and deployment tools of their choice.

However, **Nimbus by byteXL** provides the required development environment, tools and libraries needed to build and deploy hackathon solutions.

Teams are therefore encouraged to explore and build their solutions on **Nimbus**.

4. Challenge-Specific Information

Teams must provide any additional information requested as part of their selected problem statement.

15. WHO CAN SUBMIT?

Unlike problem statement locking, submission is **not restricted to the Team Lead**.

Any registered team member can submit the solution on behalf of the team.

Teams should ensure that the submitting member has access to the required platform and submission information.

16. MULTIPLE SUBMISSIONS & VERSION CONTROL

Teams are allowed to submit their solution more than once during the active submission window.

Important:

After a team submits a solution, it can continue improving the project and submit a newer version **until the official submission deadline**.

The system will accept the latest valid submission made before the deadline.

Final Submission Consideration

Once the submission deadline has passed:

The latest valid submission available on the platform at the time of closure will be considered for evaluation.

No new submission or replacement will be accepted after the deadline unless an official instruction is issued by the HacXLerate organizing team.

Recommendation

Teams are strongly advised not to wait until the final few minutes.

Submit an initial working version early and continue improving it through the remaining hackathon period.

17. SUBMISSION DEADLINE

The exact submission deadline will be based on the official start time of the participating college.

For example:

Hackathon Start: 10:00 AM

Submission Deadline: 10:00 AM the following day

The 24-hour duration is calculated from the official start time communicated for the college.

After the Deadline

Once the submission deadline has passed:

- Submissions will be closed.
 - The latest valid submission will be considered.
 - Late submissions will not be accepted.
 - Teams will not be allowed to replace their final submission unless officially authorized.
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18. AUTO EVALUATION

HacXLerate Round 1 will use an **automated evaluation layer** before human evaluation.

The purpose of automated evaluation is to verify whether the required functionalities of the selected challenge have been built and are working as required.

For example, if a challenge specifies four mandatory functionalities, the platform's evaluation framework may check whether those required functionalities are implemented and functioning.

Important Shortlisting Rule

Only teams that satisfy the required functionality criteria through the automated evaluation will proceed to human evaluation.

Teams that do not meet the required functionality threshold will not proceed to the human evaluation stage.

Therefore, teams should prioritize building **all mandatory functionalities** specified in their selected problem statement.

19. HUMAN EVALUATION

Teams that successfully clear the automated functionality evaluation will be evaluated by designated evaluators.

Human evaluation will focus on the qualitative and competitive aspects of the solution.

The overall evaluation parameters may include:

- Problem Understanding
- Functionality
- Technical Execution
- Innovation & Creativity
- User Experience
- Overall Solution Quality
- Deployment
- Scalability/Potential

Important

The exact weightage assigned to each parameter may vary by problem statement.

Teams should refer to the evaluation criteria provided with their specific challenge.

20. LIVE DEMO / CLARIFICATION

A live presentation or demo is **not mandatory by default during Round 1**.

However, evaluators may request a team to:

- Demonstrate the solution.
- Explain a specific functionality.
- Clarify an implementation.
- Verify whether a feature is working.
- Provide additional information in case of a close evaluation.

Teams should therefore remain reachable and be prepared to explain their solution if requested.

21. EVALUATION PRINCIPLES

Participants should understand that completing a functional solution is the minimum requirement for progressing through the evaluation process.

Beyond functionality, evaluators may consider:

- How well the team understood the problem.
- How effectively the solution addresses the problem.
- Quality of implementation.
- Originality and creativity.
- User experience.
- Technical depth.
- Practical applicability.
- Scalability and future potential.
- Overall quality of execution.

Teams should therefore avoid focusing only on building the minimum number of features.

22. COLLEGE-LEVEL RECOGNITION

The **Top 3 teams from each participating college** will be recognized at the college level.

The college may conduct a local announcement or recognition ceremony.

Important:

College-level Top 3 recognition **does not automatically mean qualification for Round 2**.

All eligible teams from participating colleges will be considered for the overall HacXLerate leaderboard.

23. QUALIFICATION TO ROUND 2

The **Top 50 teams overall** will qualify for Round 2.

The leaderboard will consider eligible teams across participating Round 1 colleges and the applicable External Track.

The tentative Top 50 announcement is scheduled after completion of all Round 1 events.

Participants qualifying for Round 2 will receive further instructions regarding travel, accommodation, reporting and other arrangements.

24. GRAND FINALE

The Top 7 teams from Round 2 will advance to the Grand Finale.

The Grand Finale will provide teams with an opportunity to present their solutions before the Grand Jury.

Further presentation guidelines will be communicated to the shortlisted teams.

25. CODE OF CONDUCT

All participants are expected to maintain professional conduct throughout the hackathon.

Participants must:

- Respect fellow participants.
- Respect college and byteXL staff.
- Follow instructions from authorized organizers.
- Maintain appropriate behaviour within the venue.
- Use college facilities responsibly.
- Avoid disruption to other participants.
- Protect their own and others' equipment.
- Maintain a professional and inclusive environment.

Any form of harassment, intimidation, abuse, threatening behaviour, vandalism or misconduct may result in immediate removal from the hackathon.

26. ORIGINALITY & PLAGIARISM

Teams must take responsibility for the originality and integrity of their submitted solution.

The following may result in disqualification:

- Copying another team's solution.
- Submitting another participant's work as one's own.
- Misrepresenting contributions.

- Using stolen or unauthorized source code.
- Falsifying project information.
- Manipulating submissions or evaluation systems.
- Any other form of deliberate misrepresentation.

Use of publicly available libraries, frameworks, APIs and legitimate development resources is permitted.

Use of AI tools is permitted, but the final solution remains the team's responsibility.

27. FAIR PLAY

Participants must not attempt to:

- Exploit the hackathon platform.
- Manipulate automated evaluation.
- Interfere with another team's submission.
- Gain unauthorized access to another team's repository or solution.
- Tamper with evaluation data.
- Circumvent competition rules.

Any deliberate attempt to manipulate the competition may result in immediate disqualification.

28. VENUE RULES

Since Round 1 is conducted physically at the participating college:

Participants must:

- Follow the college's campus rules.
- Follow venue-specific instructions.
- Use only designated spaces.
- Maintain cleanliness.
- Avoid damage to college property.
- Follow security and access procedures.
- Respect restrictions imposed by the college.

The college and byteXL organizing teams reserve the right to take appropriate action in case of serious venue misconduct.

29. PERSONAL DEVICES & INTERNET

Participants are expected to bring their own:

- Laptop

- Charger
- Required accessories
- Development tools/software
- Other equipment necessary to build their solution

Internet access will be facilitated at the venue as per college arrangements.

Participants are advised to keep required development tools, dependencies and resources ready before the hackathon begins.

30. PARTICIPANT SUPPORT – ZOOM HELPLINE

To support participants throughout the 24-hour hackathon, byteXL will provide a dedicated Zoom Helpline for participant queries and assistance.

- The Zoom Helpline link will be shared with participants during the pre-hackathon briefing.
- The helpline will be active during designated time windows throughout the hackathon.
- The specific active timings will be communicated during the pre-hackathon briefing based on the participating college's hackathon schedule.
- Participants can use the helpline to raise queries or seek clarification related to the hackathon, platform, submission process and other relevant aspects.
- Participants are encouraged to raise issues as early as possible and not wait until the final submission window.
- For issues that require further investigation, the support team may take the details and coordinate with the relevant HacXlerate team.

Note: The Zoom Helpline is intended for guidance and clarification. The support team will not build, debug or develop solutions on behalf of participants.

Official instructions from the HacXlerate organizing team will supersede informal information shared by participants.

31. DEADLINES & OFFICIAL COMMUNICATION

Participants are responsible for tracking all official deadlines communicated by the HacXlerate organizing team.

Important deadlines include:

- Platform access
- Problem statement selection
- Problem lock
- Submission
- Evaluation
- Results
- Round 2 qualification
- Grand Finale

Any change to an official deadline or rule will be communicated through an authorized byteXL/HacXLerate communication channel.

Participants should not rely on unofficial WhatsApp messages, social media posts or information from other participants in case of conflicting information.

32. JUDGING DECISION

The decisions of the designated evaluators/judging panel are **final and binding**.

Participants may be asked to provide clarification where necessary, but there will be no appeal process against the final judging decision.

byteXL reserves the right to:

- Verify submissions.
- Request clarification.
- Review suspicious submissions.
- Disqualify teams that violate the rules.
- Make final decisions regarding eligibility, evaluation and progression.

33. DISQUALIFICATION

A team may be disqualified for:

- Failure to select a problem statement within the stipulated time.
- Attempting to change a locked problem statement.
- Failure to meet mandatory challenge functionality requirements.
- Plagiarism or copied work.
- Misrepresentation of team members or contributions.
- Unauthorized team-member changes.
- Submission of inaccessible or invalid required links.
- Manipulation of the platform or evaluation process.
- Misconduct.
- Violation of venue rules.
- Violation of HacXLerate rules.
- Any deliberate attempt to gain an unfair advantage.

The organizing team reserves the right to disqualify a team where a serious violation is identified.

34. IMPORTANT RULES – QUICK REFERENCE

Before starting, every participant must understand these rules:

01. Platform Access

You will receive hackathon platform access on your registered email approximately **2-3 hours before the event**.

02. Physical Participation

Round 1 is a **24-hour physical hackathon conducted at your college campus**.

03. Problem Selection

You get the **first 2 hours** to understand and select your problem statement.

04. Only Team Lead Can Lock

Only the **Team Lead** can select and lock the team's problem statement.

05. Problem Cannot Be Changed

Once locked, the problem statement remains the same through:

Round 1 → Round 2 → Grand Finale

06. Build All Required Functionalities

The platform will perform **automated evaluation of the required functionalities**.

07. Auto Evaluation Comes First

Only teams that successfully satisfy the required functionality criteria will proceed to **human evaluation**.

08. Human Evaluation

Human evaluators assess innovation, creativity, technical depth, problem-solving, UX and overall solution quality, as defined by the challenge rubric.

09. Anyone on the Team Can Submit

Any registered team member can submit the solution.

10. You Can Resubmit

Teams can submit improved versions multiple times **until the deadline**.

11. Latest Submission Wins

After the deadline, the **latest valid submission on the platform will be considered final**.

12. No Late Submissions

Once the deadline closes, late submissions or replacements will not be accepted unless officially authorized.

13. AI Is Allowed

AI tools can be used throughout the hackathon.

14. Live Demo Is Not Mandatory

A live demo is not required by default, but evaluators may request one for verification or clarification.

15. Top 3 ≠ Round 2

Top 3 teams at each college receive college-level recognition. **The Top 50 overall teams qualify for Round 2.**

16. Judging Is Final

The decision of the designated evaluators/judging panel is **final and binding**.

35. PARTICIPANT CHECKLIST

Before the hackathon:

- Registered team confirmed
- Team has 3–5 members
- All members belong to the same college
- Valid college ID available
- Laptop ready
- Charger ready
- Required software/tools installed
- Registered email accessible
- Platform access checked
- Team Lead identified
- Team understands the 2-hour problem-lock window
- Team understands the submission process

During the hackathon:

- Problem statement reviewed carefully
- Team Lead locks the problem within 2 hours
- All mandatory functionalities identified
- Development completed
- Solution tested
- Solution deployed
- GitHub repository ready
- Required project information completed
- Initial submission made before the deadline
- Improvements submitted as required
- Latest version verified before deadline

Before submission closes:

- Deployed link works
- GitHub link works
- Repository is accessible
- Required features are functional

- All required fields are completed
 - Latest version has been submitted
 - Team has verified the final submission
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36. FINAL MESSAGE TO PARTICIPANTS

HacXLerate is not just about completing a hackathon.

It is an opportunity to understand a real-world problem, make decisions under time pressure, build a working solution and demonstrate what you can do beyond the classroom.

Use the 24 hours wisely.

Understand the problem.

Build with purpose.

Use technology creatively.

Complete every required functionality.

Test your solution.

Submit on time.

CODE. CREATE. INNOVATE.
